

HOW MANY CALORIES DO YOU ACTUALLY NEED TO LOSE WEIGHT?

The exact math behind your daily calorie target, from BMR to a sustainable deficit.

"Lose weight" advice is everywhere, but almost nobody hands you the actual number, how many calories should you be eating today, this week, to see the scale move without wrecking your energy or your relationship with food? The number is not a mystery and it is not a guess, it is a calculation you can run yourself in about two minutes, and once you understand it, every deficit conversation you have with a coach makes a lot more sense.

Start With BMR: The Energy You Burn Just Existing

Your basal metabolic rate (BMR) is the number of calories your body burns in a day if you did nothing but lie there, breathing, circulating blood, keeping your organs and brain running. It's the floor of your daily energy needs, and for most people it's the single biggest chunk of total calories burned, bigger than exercise, bigger than walking around, bigger than digesting food.

The most widely used formula for estimating it is the Mifflin-St Jeor equation, and it only needs three numbers: your weight, height, and age.

- **Men:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) + 5$
- **Women:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) - 161$

Let's run it for a real example: a 42-year-old woman who weighs 80 kg (about 176 lbs) and stands 165 cm tall (about 5'5"). Plug those numbers in: $(10 \times 80) + (6.25 \times 165) - (5 \times 42) - 161 = 800 + 1,031.25 - 210 - 161 = \mathbf{1,460 \text{ calories}}$. That's roughly what her body burns in a day before she takes a single step.

From BMR to TDEE: Adding in Real Life

BMR only covers "lying still." To find your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE), the actual number of calories you burn in a normal day, you multiply BMR by an activity multiplier that reflects how much you move:

- **Sedentary** (desk job, little intentional exercise): $BMR \times 1.2$
- **Lightly active** (some walking, light exercise a few days a week): $BMR \times 1.375$
- **Moderately active** (structured training most days): $BMR \times 1.55$
- **Very active** (hard daily training or a physically demanding job): $BMR \times 1.725$

Continuing the example above: our 42-year-old client is starting a weight-loss program with three lifting days and a couple of walks worked in, that lands her closer to lightly active. $1,460 \times 1.375 = 2,008$ **calories**. That's roughly what it takes to maintain her current weight, no gain, no loss.

Turning TDEE Into a Weight-Loss Target

Weight loss happens when intake sits consistently below TDEE, but "consistently below" does not mean "as low as possible." A moderate, sustainable deficit of roughly **15-20% below maintenance** is the range that tends to produce steady fat loss without the extreme hunger, energy crashes, and eventual rebound that come with slashing calories too hard. For our example client, that is 2,008 minus 15-20%, or roughly **1,600 to 1,700 calories a day**. Not 1,200. Not a number pulled from a fad diet, a number built from her actual body and activity level.

A Simple Way to Fill That Number

You don't need to weigh every gram to hit a target like this consistently. Anchor each meal around a palm-sized portion of protein, since it's the macronutrient most responsible for keeping you full and protecting your muscle in a deficit, then fill the rest of the plate with vegetables for volume, a moderate portion of carbohydrate sized to your activity that day, and a bit of fat worked in. Get protein and food volume right first, the exact deficit number does the rest of the work.

Where Supplements Fit In (and Where They Don't)

No supplement creates a deficit, only your food and activity totals do that. But hitting a higher daily protein target while you are eating less overall food can be genuinely hard, which is where a whey protein option like **XS™ Whey Protein** can help, it makes it easier to close a protein gap without adding much extra volume of food to an already-reduced calorie budget. If you want to explore that or other training-support options, take a look at [the Echelon Goods shop](#).

What This Means for You

- Your calorie target is not a guess, it comes from BMR (Mifflin-St Jeor), multiplied by an activity factor to get TDEE, then adjusted down for your goal.
- A 15-20% deficit below TDEE is the sustainable range for most people, not an aggressive crash-diet cut.
- Protein first, food volume second, exact number third, that order makes a deficit livable instead of miserable.
- Recalculate roughly every 10-15 lbs lost, since a lighter body needs fewer calories to maintain itself.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or nutrition advice. If you have a medical condition or are taking medication, talk to your doctor or a registered dietitian before making significant dietary changes.